

A Day in the Life of a Senior Manager at Amazon

A representative log of what one day might look like for a Senior Manager at Amazon. Guest post from former Amazon director Dave Anderson



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👋 Hi, this is Gergely with a 📩 subscriber-only issue 📩 of the Pragmatic Engineer Newsletter. In every issue, I cover challenges at Big Tech and startups through the lens of engineering managers and senior engineers.

Before we jump in, an update on the Tech Leader's Compensation survey. At the end of April, I asked for your help in sharing your compensation details, so that with VC firm CREANDUM we could share more information about startup and scaleup leadership compensation.

I'm happy to share that a deepdive on the results, produced by VC firm [CREANDUM](#), is out, and you can [read it here](#). I will follow up with additional analysis and context in the coming months, sharing my analysis with newsletter readers. If you are interested in how tech leaders are being compensated at startups in the Europe – with details on median compensation in the US, Asia and as well the US, Asia, and other regions – see the report here:

Today, there is no [The Pulse](#): I'll be back covering and analyzing recent events next week! Instead, I'm sharing my favorite reads this year on engineering management. This piece comes from [Dave Anderson](#).

Dave worked at Amazon for 12 years: starting from a junior software development manager in Global Payments, then two promotions in the 3rd Party Selling Marketplace, then AWS, then was promoted to Director of Technology running the Amazon Kids technology in devices, and then became the General Manager for Publishing in the

Amazon Games organization. He left Amazon two years ago and writes a weekly [newsletter called Scarlet Ink](#) about leadership, interviewing and career growth.

I caught up with Dave a few weeks ago. We had been mutually reading each other's articles, and we also started writing our newsletters around the same time, and both after leaving our positions at larger tech companies.

Dave published the below article in March, for paid subscribers. With permission, I'm posting the full article. I hope you enjoy this variation in the topic and style!

If you're in a management position: compare notes on how Dave's "day in a life" compares to yours - as well as your inbox growing, over the day. And if you're an individual contributor: you might get a bit more empathy on what it means to be a manager in a large tech company, and get a sense of some of the less obvious challenges with management: the never-ending context switches.

With this, over to Dave:

Time	Emails
7:15am	127 unread emails
7:21am	129 unread emails
7:38am	132 unread emails
7:59am	124 unread emails
8:04am	132 unread emails
8:32am	139 unread emails
9:42am	151 unread emails
10:05am	118 unread emails
10:31am	128 unread emails
10:41am	134 unread emails
11:03am	147 unread emails
12:05pm	161 unread emails
12:33pm	173 unread emails
1:06pm	181 unread emails

A preview of a day in a life of a Senior Manager at Amazon

When interviewing people at Amazon, I was often asked what a *normal* day looks like. If I was interviewing a manager, it was because they were curious about their responsibilities. If I was interviewing a non-manager, it was because they were curious what the heck managers do with all their time.

The actual answer is hard to give because every day was always different. Particularly as you got a bit more senior.

Some days completely revolved around a particular operational issue. Another day I'd be mostly engaged in some performance management process, such as writing [promotion documents](#), or perhaps trying to balance my team's compensation budget. Yet another day I'd be in a couple of long meetings all day, doing annual planning.

However, *most* days had a good mixture of focus on product, people, projects, and technology. The dev manager job is not great for those who love to focus for 6-hours straight, but it's pretty good for those who love variety.

I spent quite a few years at Amazon as various levels of [engineering management](#). When I was thinking of writing down a "*standard*" day for a dev manager, I decided I should pick the hardest dev manager job at Amazon. In my opinion, that's the Senior Development Manager (Level 7). I'll explain some other time why I feel Level 7 can be pretty rough.

This isn't a real day. However, it is a *realistic* day, and contains components of real days I experienced. With [privacy / confidentiality changes](#) as I feel necessary.

7:15 am - 127 unread emails

I really don't like mornings, but traffic is a beast if I get into work much later. I also want to have a chance to go through my important emails before my meetings start. I start my day with email because most of my critical things arrive in email.

127 unread emails. I'm happy to see that number because there would usually be more. But last night I'd gotten down to inbox zero, so I only had the emails for the last 13 hours or so. Yes, 127 emails in the last 13 hours. And I'd made a point of not looking at my email for those 13 hours because I find that too many annoying things land in my email box at night. I have a harder time sleeping if I read email when I'm at home. I figure if there's an emergency, I'm easy to reach.

I scanned down the list of recently received emails, looking to see if there's anything critical I need to look at first.

I see dozens of automated emails. I have various reports on ticket counts, availability of our systems, and employees who didn't take enough vacation days. I have a couple automated reminder emails that I need to baseline (essentially confirm) some permissions for employees, and systems.

I have the usual alerts of a few systems going down, and 1 minute later being available again. The teams responsible insists that they're false alarms, but I make a mental note to try to harass some engineering managers about them when I have a chance. Those alerts have been going on for too long. I want us to either fix our alarms, or find out what's going wrong.

I notice an email from [Blanca](#), a trusted senior engineer. She sent an email a couple of hours ago. The subject reads, *"all good now."* Curious, because I didn't know that things weren't good, I click on it. The body of the email reads, *"I got it working, I'll figure out why it was down later."* I don't see an email from her manager, Orville.

I wonder what was down, and suspect that I probably have other emails about it. I hope it wasn't anything serious. Since no one called me, it's likely to not be a huge deal. I decide to look through my inbox to see if I can figure out what went wrong.

At that moment, someone knocks at my door. It's my manager, Glenn.

7:21 am - 129 unread emails

"Hey Dave. I heard that there might have been an outage with the notification platform. Do you know if that's fixed yet?"

Ah, mystery probably solved.

"I'm reasonably confident that Blanca got it fixed, but she's still investigating. I'll double-check and let you know asap."

A successful manager can do two things particularly well. First, they keep their team shielded from distractions, so they can get things done. Second, they make certain that they shield their manager from worry and stress, by being competent, and convincing their manager that everything is completely under control at all times.

This means I instant message Blanca as soon as Glenn walks out.

"Hey Blanca, thanks for the updates this morning. Just a quick question. Was the 'all good' message about the notification platform? I wanted to double-check because Glenn was asking about it, and I wanted to make certain I wasn't wrong."

Blanca thankfully replies a few seconds later. "Yes".

Well, maybe she uses fewer words than I'd prefer, but she's a good engineer. That's enough confirmation for now. I message Glenn that I was right, the notification system is fixed. I assure him that I'll make certain he'll get a more complete update by the end of the day.

I often phrase things like, *"you'll get a more complete update"* instead of *"I'll send you a more complete update"* because Orville owns the notification system, and he's the one I'd expect to send updates to everyone. However, Orville has a bad habit of not communicating well, which is likely why Blanca messaged me directly. I get the impression she doesn't respect Orville much.

7:38 am - 132 unread emails

I double-check my inbox. Now that I'm looking closer, I do see some emails about the notification platform going down. I also see nothing from Orville, and no other messages about that outage. After any major outage, I'd expect someone to send an update out. If you're not proactive, people worry.

I email Orville, and ask him to please send a summary of what happened with the notification system to myself, Glenn, and anyone else he feels is appropriate.

I emailed him because we usually used email for non-urgent messages (sometime in the next few hours), and IM for urgent messages. I also feel that people read their IMs at home, or in the car, and then forget to do what they were asked later. I know Orville gets to work later, and this can wait until then.

As a manager thing, I made sure to add "*anyone else he feels is appropriate*" because he does have a set of internal customers. I, personally, know that he should add them to the email. Orville should know that as well by now. I added that hint because if Orville doesn't email them (and I give it a 50/50 shot), I have a specific instance I can give him feedback on. It sounds sneaky, but you need clear examples of someone making mistakes to be able to coach them. And you can't have a manager who can't independently manage things.

7:59 am - 124 unread emails

I read through every email I could find about the notification system, read the event trouble ticket timeline, and looked at a few online dashboards. I didn't feel comfortable going to my first meetings without knowing what happened. Which means I spent a bit over 15 minutes researching the outage that I should have been able to trust Orville to deal with. Bah humbug. But at least now I understand what happened.

8:04 am - 125 unread emails

I sit down in my first meeting of the day. Almost every meeting consistently starts 5 minutes late. Unless it's with an important executive, in which case everyone shows up 5 minutes early. Even if the executives are often late. I remember Bezos would show up 15 minutes or an hour late, or often you'd sit in the conference room for an hour, and then someone would let our conference room know that Jeff can't meet today, but they'll reschedule.

This is an hour-long meeting where the product team is reviewing a proposal for a new feature for our system. They said they're showing a few stakeholders an early draft of the document for comment.

I'm the only engineering representative. Once I look at the invite, I see that Lillie, the engineering manager for that team, was not invited. I suspect it's because the product manager and Lillie don't get along well. Regardless, I forward an invite to Lillie, and message her if she's available to meet now. She is, and heads over to the conference room.

The product manager looks surprised and disappointed when she shows up a couple of minutes later. Yeah, he probably preferred it if she didn't attend. It's hard to make two other people be polite to each other.

We all read for about 30 minutes. I read quickly, and so I'm done in around 15. I open Outlook, to catch up on some email.

For those who are not paid, this is where the article ends. If you'd like to get the rest of the article, you have two choices:

- [Subscribe to The Pragmatic Engineer](#), and get this article, and all future ones.
- Alternatively, you can subscribe [to Scarlet Ink](#) - Dave's newsletter - and get [the rest of the article](#), and future ones Dave writes.

I'd suggest subscribing to one or both publications to get access to tech industry insights that can help during your day-to-day.

8:32 am - 132 unread emails

I email a couple of my managers, asking them to please look into the false alarms, to please verify that they're false alarms, and do something about them.

Then I notice an email from Blanca, summarizing the notification system outage. She copied me, Orville (her boss), and a couple of stakeholders. Good for her. I wonder if Orville asked her to do it. I'm ok with people delegating in general, but it bothers me a bit if he had her write the summary. He doesn't have a great track record of diving deep, and I really wanted to see him take personal ownership of this.

I skim Blanca's email, and see that it matches what I understood earlier, with a few more details. Perhaps a bit technical for an executive summary, but not bad. I forward it to my boss Glenn. I add a note that Blanca wrote a nice technical update. And I hope it answers any questions he has. I figure it's unlikely he'll care to follow up more.

The product manager confirms that everyone is done reading, and asks for feedback. We provide our thoughts on the technical changes needed. The designer asks some questions about how the existing UX might need to change. I ask a couple of questions about the customer survey they said they ran. Lillie makes a couple of remarks, indicating her displeasure at everything in the document. Because clearly I need to deal with that today.

9:03 am - 139 unread emails

I hurry to my next meeting. It's an hour-long review with everyone in management of all in-flight projects for the department. We start with projects in dire risk, then moderate risk, and then the project managers tend to waste everyone's time by talking about the projects which are doing just fine.

One of the first projects mentioned is run by another senior manager. Their project launch is slipping for the 4th week in a row, by a week. I remember last week they said, *"We ran into a little complexity, but we should get this into QA by next week."* This week they said, *"We ran into a little complexity, but we should get this into QA by next week."*

The project manager running the meeting nods, and tries to move to the next item. I speak up because I really can't help myself. And I'd like to believe it's my job.

"One second. You said that last week. Has anything changed?"

The senior manager looks uncomfortable. I can immediately tell that he was hoping to just slide by without comment.

"Well, I think maybe it's a new bug? I'll have to check." Ah, I see. He didn't know the status of his stuff, so he was winging it.

Now the project manager is happy to do their project managing thing. *"I'll write down an action item for you to follow up with this group by the end of the day on the status of the bug, and your new ETA?"*

The senior manager reluctantly agrees. While it can feel like red tape, those action items really work. It'll make the senior manager find out what's going on. When organizations grow, it's always a risk that things will fall between the cracks, particularly with leaders who lose track of the details.

9:42 am - 151 unread emails

We finished going over the moderate risk projects. The project manager says that it's now time to go over the green projects.

This feels like a waste of my time, and I'd like to get some time back. [I stand up, and walk out](#). A couple of other people follow. That makes me happy. Every so often, these actions are what it takes to get a change made. I make a mental note (which I promptly forget) to suggest to the project manager that they change their agenda.

I hurry to my desk, dock my laptop, and start at my oldest emails. I try to go through them as fast as possible.

10:05 am - 118 unread emails

I just arrived at a 30-minute [COE review](#) run by one of the managers in my organization. The team asks for everyone to read for 10 minutes, and then we can discuss. I read the COE. It's incredibly detailed. I'm proud of them. It goes into incredible depth discussing an issue they'd run into a couple of weeks ago.

I think I could probably just leave, since they seem to have things well in hand, but leaving would send the wrong impression for how important this is. So I am the first to speak, asking a softball question about one of their planned action items. They excitedly confirm that they are indeed going to fix that. I thank them, and explain that this is an extremely well-written COE.

As I'm about to leave the meeting to head to my first one-on-one of the day, I notice a new email arrive in my inbox from Orville. It's addressed to me and Glenn.

It explains that there was no notification system outage. *"Those alarms are a false alarm, we'll get them addressed soon."*

Sigh. What the heck Orville. As far as I can tell, this is incorrect nonsense. I imagine he confused my email about false alarms with my email asking for an update, and quickly fired off an email.

10:31 am - 128 unread emails

I find Orville at his desk.

"Hey Orville. You said the notification system was a false alarm, but there was a real outage this morning, and Blanca got it fixed. You just said it was a false alarm?"

Orville looks like a deer in the headlights. *"I'll talk to Blanca and see what she did."*

"Blanca already sent out a summary. Please take a look at it, catch up on things with Blanca, and then send a proper update to us? Orville, you really need to be careful, this isn't the first time you've sent out a wrong update."

Orville nods.

I walk over to Glenn's office. Thankfully, Glenn is at his desk. Glenn notices me approaching.

"What was that Orville sent about the false alarm?"

"Please just ignore that. Orville wasn't caught up on things and shouldn't have sent you that update without catching up first. He'll send a real update later."

Glenn nods. *"I still don't think Orville is doing a good job. Are you giving him enough feedback?"*

I agree that I'm going to give Orville more feedback. Every single one-on-one with Orville contains feedback about things he needs to improve. [It's probably pretty unpleasant for him](#). But it's better than him not realizing that he's having issues.

10:41 am - 134 unread emails

I get to my desk, and my one-on-one employee is there waiting for me, typing away at her laptop. She's a senior engineer working for me directly. I apologize profusely for showing up late, and insist we can get more time. She says it's not a big deal, she doesn't have much on her agenda.

We spend around 15 minutes going over her slides for a presentation she'd like to give for the women in engineering group. I give her some advice on the content, and ask her questions about the audience to make certain the content works. Otherwise, I ask her some questions about her next project, and she confirms that her career goals are progressing fine.

We wrap things up, and I remind her that she should just let me know if she'd like more time, I'd be happy to accommodate. She says we're all good for this week.

11:03 am - 147 unread emails

My next one-on-one is with a manager on my team. It's an hour long.

We discuss his team members (there some drama between two engineers), the status of his projects (he needs to flag a couple of his projects at-risk), and some technical work his team is doing.

Time flies, and we're discussing various topics until our time is up.

12:05 pm - 161 unread emails

Officially, I have 12-1pm blocked on my calendar every day for lunch. And yet, every day I have one critical meeting or another booked on top of my lunch.

Today, we're in a 30-minute review for some last-minute changes to our marketing campaign. The marketing team is planning on changing some content, emphasizing a

new feature (which recently launched), and wants to make certain our engineering team can report on some new aspects of campaign success. I write up a summary of their questions, and send it off to a couple of engineers (and their manager) to get an answer.

12:33 pm - 173 unread emails

Now I have a technical review of a redesign of one of our core services. The meeting is 1 hour long, but I let them know I can only stay for 30 minutes.

I read the document quickly, and ask a few questions about their design plans. In particular, I point out that one of our current challenges is that launching this service in a new country is expensive.

I ask if the new design improves this because that was one of the arguments for why they needed to redesign this in the first place.

The engineers look at each other, and say that this new design doesn't address that issue.

"We intended to redesign, and then we could look at that problem next. When the system is easier to update because it's redesigned."

I ask them to please go look at that problem right now because the number one issue with this system is that country launches are expensive. They agree. As I leave the meeting room, I hear their manager asking that the rest of the meeting be cancelled, so their team can go discuss things.

1:06 pm - 181 unread emails

Orville comes into my office for his one-on-one. He says that Blanca already sent out an update on the outage, and so he's not planning on sending one. And then he tries to move onto a project status discussion.

I explain that Blanca's update was a technical explanation of the outage. I'd like to see a message from him summarizing the outage for Glenn and myself, but also explain more

high-level details. Will his team write a COE? Was there a customer impact, and what was it? Overall, I'd like him to demonstrate ownership over the event.

He says he'll write that up. I'm unfortunately not confident he can. This wouldn't be the first time I asked him to do something like this, and he does something inadequate.

I give Orville more verbal feedback on how he should approach this, and email him with my expectations. You always want written documentation when someone isn't consistently doing what is needed.

We eventually get onto his other agenda items. We discuss some employees on his team, and a project he'd like to get started soon. Orville isn't a bad guy, he's just not great at his job.

2:04 pm - 192 unread emails

I thankfully have a complete block on my calendar for the next hour. I don't always manage to preserve these blocks, but I do my best.

I close my office door, and put on my headphones. Time to catch up on some things.

2:51 pm - 49 unread emails

I'm pretty darn good at power reading emails. However, I did the easy 80% of my emails first. The easy emails include those automated emails, the ones I was CC'd on for no reason, and those *"FYI, here's a 7-page status report for a project without any problems, but someone loves their reports and got carried away"* emails.

The next emails should be easy. They require some replies, but don't take too long.

From an engineer on Orville's team, *"Dave, can we have permission to launch X feature one sprint later? Would the PMs be ok with that?"*

I reply-all (which includes Orville), CC the PMs, and ask the question. Because oh my gosh people, why ask me?

From a finance manager, *"Managers, can you please reply with your headcount requests for all of your projects for next year by Friday?"*

I reply, and ask how that's possible, considering we don't know what projects will be approved for next year, until our meeting with the SVP in 2 weeks.

From one of the managers on my team, *"Dave, do you have any objections to this [CM](#)? We're decreasing the QA cycle from 5 days to 4 days."*

I reply that it sounds fine if that's what she wants to do. It's always a good idea to approve people's ideas, unless you have a strong reason to stop them. Autonomy feels good to everyone.

From our recruiting partner for my team, *"Hey Dave, can you be the [BR](#) for an interview tomorrow at 2pm? I see you're busy, but it's important. Our BR cancelled last minute."*

I look at my calendar, ask someone to please move a meeting, and agree with the recruiter that they can send me an invite. It's pretty important that those interviews get done on schedule.

And I continue answering those easy emails as fast as possible.

2:58 pm - 53 unread emails

The funny thing about reading and sending a lot of emails quickly is that you start to get quite a few replies. It starts to look like a boomerang. As fast as I'm closing emails, I'm receiving replies to things. Bah.

3:04 pm - 51 unread emails

I have a 30-minute meeting with the finance team to go over our growth projections for next year. It's one of the components of our annual planning, and I need to make certain the numbers make sense. In particular, I don't want them assuming anything will be built which I don't know about.

It turns out two country launches we'd already cut were in their financial projections. I ask them to talk to the product manager in charge of those country launches to confirm

that they need to revise those numbers.

I also ask why I need to update my headcount requests, when we don't have our headcount yet. They say that they need a list of projects we *think* will be approved, and the headcount those projects would need.

I say this is nonsense. They agree. I explain that we have a lot of steps left before we decide on the actual official requests, we need to review with our Directors and VPs, plus we don't know what our SVP will approve. We have many steps left. They repeat that they really need those numbers, even if they're not approved.

I repeat that this is nonsense, and they agree again.

3:32 pm - 57 unread emails

I load up the excel document with the project requests from our engineering team, and our product team. If every project was approved, we'd have 189% growth. It's a bit much. I cut the projects I think don't make a ton of sense (from both engineering and product), and get our headcount growth down to 30%. I think around 20% is likely to be approved, but I feel ambitious. Plus, I have no idea who will see this. I don't want to start with a low number.

I send the project list and headcount needs to the finance team, reminding them that this is completely made up, I'd only spent 5 minutes on it, it was temporary, and has nothing to do with reality. I copy Glenn because these types of things have a habit of becoming annoying.

3:37 pm - 61 unread emails

I'm in a 30-minute design review for a new login page. They're looking at adding some single sign-on security features to login across our sites, and wanted to make certain it looks consistent and professional. It looks fine to me.

4:04 pm - 74 unread emails

Now I have a 30-minute review of the launch plan for a new feature for one of my teams. It has the QA, marketing, and PR steps outlined, for the pre and post-launch

activities.

I suggest that the QA team probably wants to add a bit more time into their QA schedule because it feels aggressive. They say that they don't have more time, because the launch date is approaching.

I remind them that the launch date was planned 9 months ago, and we shouldn't hold ourselves to it, if it's the wrong thing to do.

The marketing team reminds us that they need to lock in all their marketing 6-weeks in advance because, for some mysterious reason, modern marketing still has an incredibly slow change time. The PR team says that we can't do marketing if we're not going to launch the feature. I agree because that certainly does sound like a bad idea.

We end up slipping the schedule by a couple of weeks to accommodate more QA time. The marketing team grumbles, but says they'll update their campaigns.

4:36 pm - 97 unread emails

I decide to read some emails before going home.

The first email I see is from the marketing team to the finance team. One of those random emails I'm copied on for no clear reason. They say that they'll need to update their budget because Project Q was cancelled, and so they don't need advertising for Project Q.

I see a reply to that email from the product team, insisting that they redirect their funding to Project J, which was not cancelled.

I see an email from finance, saying that they're updating the costs of Project J with the new marketing spend.

I see the marketing team replies, suggesting that they need to have a Project J meeting, to discuss the new enlarged marketing approach.

I realize all of this is because I didn't fund Project Q in my completely made up, temporary financial projections. I decide I don't have the mental energy to deal with this

right now, so I switch to reading a different email.

Glenn swings by a few minutes later.

"Hey Dave, I heard you cancelled Project Q?"

I groan.

Glenn laughs. *"It would probably be cancelled anyway. It's not a big deal. Just keep it cancelled for now, and we'll figure out the real approved and not-approved list next week."*

I agree, and happily stop stressing over the Project Q and J email thread.

4:59 pm - 71 unread emails

I decide I spent far more time than planned at work today, so I shut my laptop and leave.

The next day.

7:13 am - 214 unread emails

I see other senior managers cancelled Project Q in their plans. Because marketing pulled their budget. Because I cancelled it in my team's budget. Whoops.

1:50 pm - 179 unread emails

It turns out that my BR interview is for a business marketing data analytics position. I don't know what the role does, so I read the job description before the interview to understand the expectations of the role. Being a [bar raiser](#) for a position you're not familiar with is fun. Helps me learn things.

3:19 pm - 197 unread emails

Orville sends what looks to be Blanca's update to me and Glenn, and says that a COE is not necessary because the fix was easy. I groan, and head over to talk to Orville.

Every day is different.

When your organization is large enough, these types of things are always happening. There's always an Orville you're trying to deal with. There's always great employees like Blanca, who are just quietly doing their job. Hopefully, you have a good manager like Glenn, who has high expectations, but isn't a jerk.

I hope you enjoyed this exercise.

This is Gergely again.

Thanks, Dave, for sharing this entertainingly granular description of a "day in a life." If you enjoyed this piece, subscribe to [Dave's newsletter here](#), and follow Dave [on LinkedIn](#) where he frequently shares thoughts and reflections on leadership and Amazon.



271 Likes · 5 Restacks

23 Comments



Write a comment...



F Riker Jul 27 ❤️ Liked by Gergely Orosz

Anyone else experience second hand stress while reading this?

♡ LIKE (23) 💬 REPLY ...

1 reply



Noah Jul 27 ❤️ Liked by Gergely Orosz

What a great day recap. Was it weird that I wanted to read more days of this managers life?

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